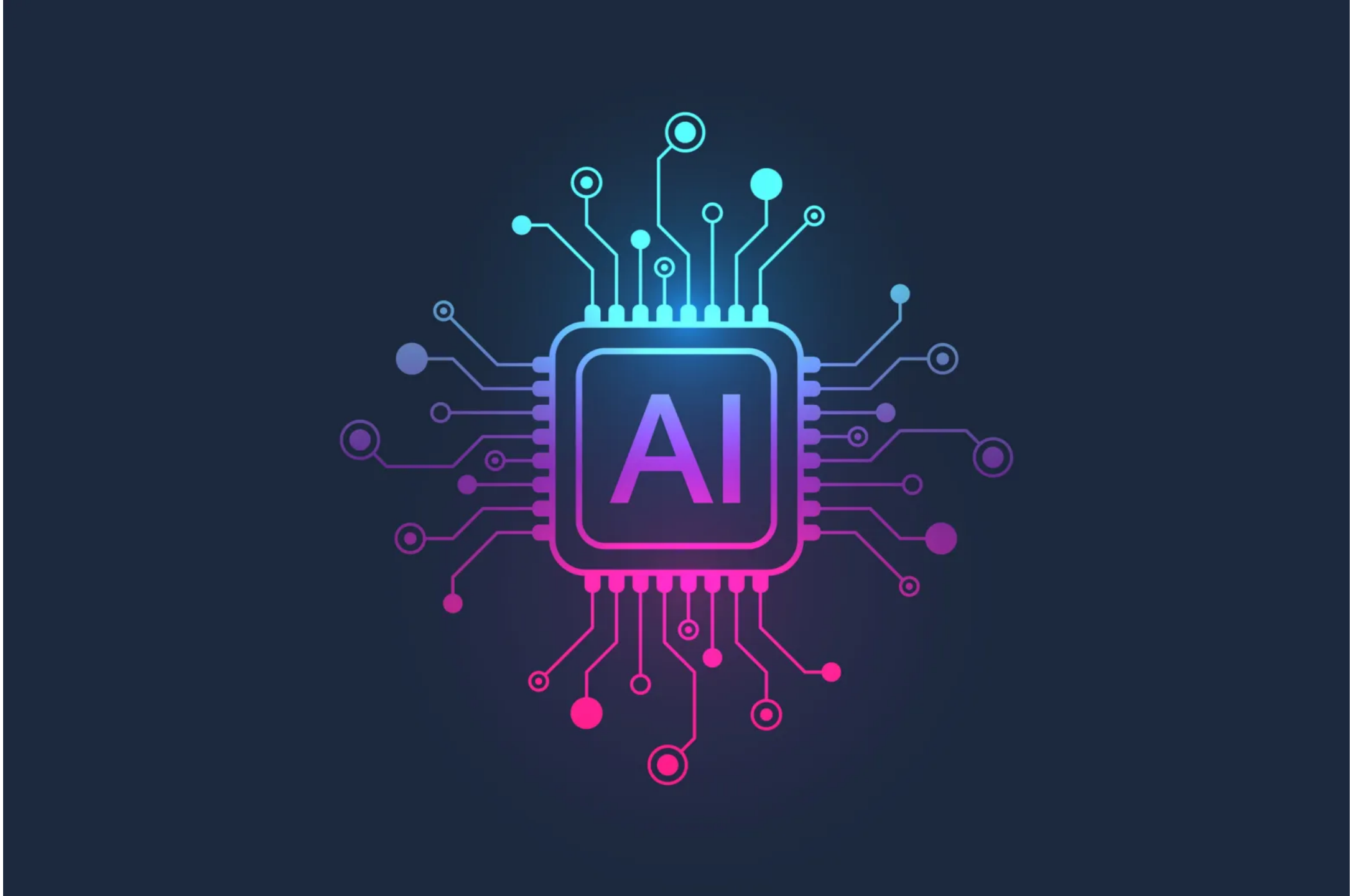




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Opinion: Public workers in the Bay Area lay the groundwork for AI rules

‘This is our moment to prove that the most innovative thing a government can do is put its people first.’



Local governments are on the frontlines of defining the boundaries of AI. Getty Images

By **MARIA NOEL FERNANDEZ** and **RIKO MENDEZ**
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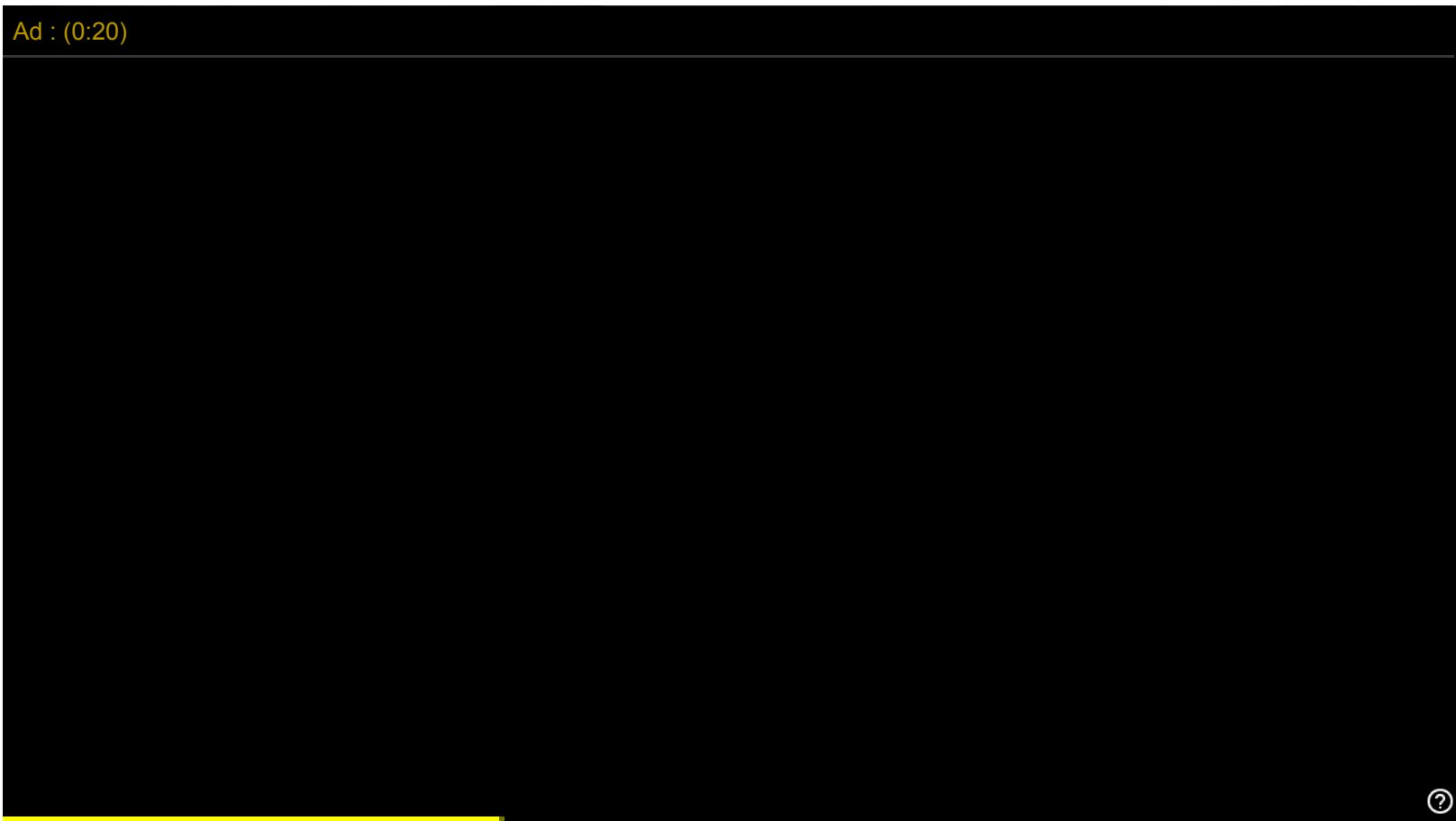
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A nurse flags that the AI transcription system is putting wrong words in her notes, and no one in charge wants to hear it. A benefits caseworker watches a family get cut off by an algorithm he doesn't have the authority to override. These aren't hypotheticals. They are happening right now in hospitals, courthouses and government offices across California.

Artificial intelligence is reshaping our workplaces, our public services and our communities. But who benefits, and who pays the price, is an open question. And the answer depends on choices being made right now, including here in Santa Clara County.

We represent public workers, and advocate for communities at the intersection of economic justice and emerging technology. We're tired of watching the same playbook: deploy fast, skip worker input, call it innovation, and when things go wrong, let workers and residents absorb the damage. We saw it when DOGE staffers used an AI tool that recommended cutting services veterans depend on. We see it every time a system denies benefits or misreads a courtroom transcript, and the worker on the frontline gets blamed for a failure they never had the power to prevent.

Frontline public employees are not obstacles to technological progress. They are its most important quality-control system. The nurse who catches the wrong transcription. The caseworker who knows a family's file. When workers are cut out of the design and implementation of these systems, the systems fail, and real people suffer the consequences. And it's not just workers who pay the price. It's the people wrongly denied benefits with no one to push back, the patients whose care suffers with no one to catch the error and the families navigating systems not knowing how decisions get made.

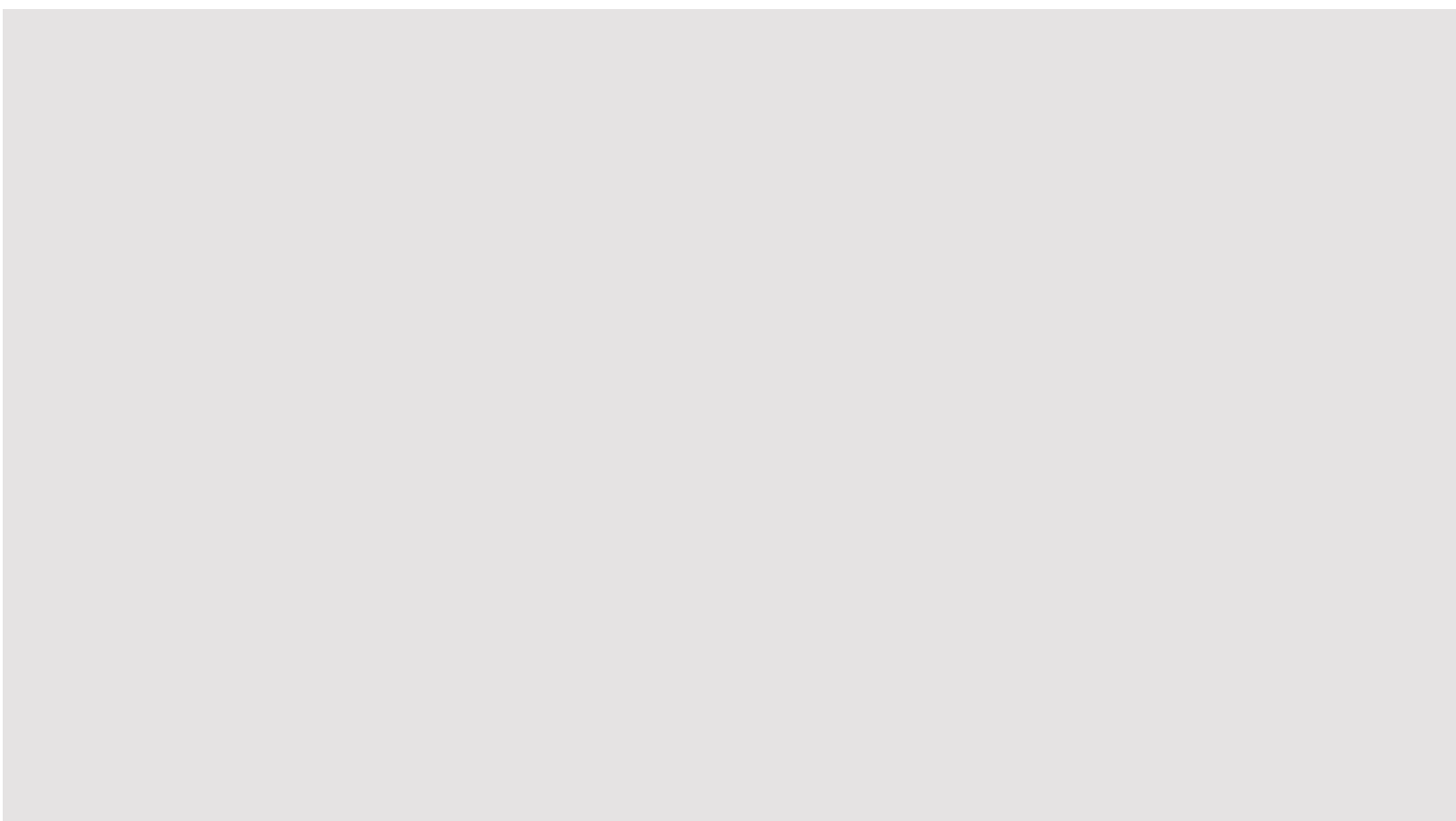


In Santa Clara County, we have the opportunity to do this differently. On March 24, the Board of Supervisors, led by Supervisor Margaret Abe Koga with support and input from our county's labor unions, ordered a comprehensive study on AI use across county departments, to set guidelines so future technology solutions improve jobs instead of replacing them. They also committed to co-designing AI systems with workers, ensuring human review, and guaranteeing the right to appeal. These are not small things. They are a foundation.

Now we must build on it. That means clear rules and oversight for technology affecting civil rights, public services or equal opportunity; protecting employee and resident data; and ensuring algorithms don't drive decisions about wages, discipline or hiring without accountability and transparency. It means no black boxes.

Polls show Americans overwhelmingly support regulating AI, across party lines, across generations. The public wants something reasonable: responsible deployment with their interests in mind, not just those of a trillion-dollar industry selling to governments with almost no guardrails

Unions and community organizations are stepping up to fill the vacuum left by the absence of federal policy. In San Jose, AFSCME Local 101 and IFPTE Local 21 are pushing for AI safeguards through contract negotiations, including a joint oversight committee to review new systems before they're deployed. Valley Transportation Authority employees recently won a say in how new technology gets adopted. Workers are not at the table to slow down progress, but to make sure progress actually means something for working families.



What Santa Clara County decides in the coming months will not stay within our borders. The precedents we set on transparency, worker voice and accountability will ripple outward. That is not a burden but an opportunity. This is our moment to prove that the most innovative thing a government can do is put its people first.

Maria Noel Fernandez is the executive director of Working Partnerships USA. Riko Mendez is the chief elected officer of SEIU Local 521.

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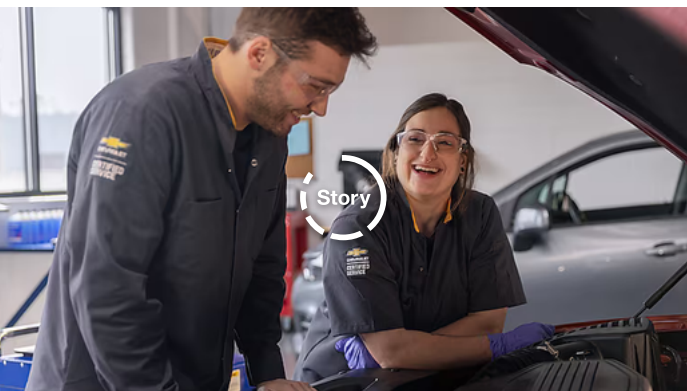
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